The 6:15

MONDAY · OCTOBER 26, 2026 NO. 31

THE BOARD

CALENDAR — NEXT 10 DAYS

Tonight	World Series Gm 3, Brewers at Rays, Tampa Bay (FOX) — Brewers lead 2-0
Tue-Wed 10/27-28	FOMC, 2:00p ET decision Wed. — hold priced ~90%, hike ~9-10% **(correction: thin as that is, it is hike risk, not the cut risk recent issues carried)**
Thu 10/29, 8:30a	Q3 GDP advance estimate; Sept. PCE/personal income (BEA)
Sat 11/1	OPEC+ meets — no agenda details verified this run
Tue 11/3	US midterm elections

Microsoft/Alphabet/Amazon/Meta and Coca-Cola/Boeing earnings dates: **not verified this run** [continuity]. No rocket launch, frontier-AI release or major VC round verified this run.

METRICS · AS OF ~6A ET UNLESS NOTED

Brent / WTI	$115.10 (-1.39%) / $101.45 (-1.76%), oilprice.com ~6:00a ET **(~11-min delayed feed)**; spread ~$13.65
2y/10y/30y UST	**not confirmed as of press time** — Treasury.gov stuck on Aug. 25 data; last verified Fri. close 4.69%/5.00%/5.33%
S&P / Nasdaq fut.	S&P +0.30% to 7,682.75 (Yahoo Finance, 6:11a ET); Nasdaq 100 fut. +0.2% (Bloomberg)
VIX	**not confirmed as of press time**; last verified Fri. 19.45 (+2.21%)
DXY	~101.6-101.8, falling (FXStreet, 5:32a ET)
Gold	$4,005.20, +$10.30 (Kitco, 2:18a ET); Investing.com $4,017.13; Mitrade ~$3,988 **(~$30 cross-feed spread)**
Asia / Europe closes	**not confirmed as of press time**
Retail gas (AAA)	$4.2858/gal (10/26), down from $4.2957 (10/24) [NEW — breaks 3-day rise streak]

Crude: ICE Brent/NYMEX WTI front-month. Rates: Treasury.gov. Equities/FX/gold: exchange feeds as cited; feeds disagree by design on gold — reported side by side, not averaged.

HORMUZ COUNTERS

Status	Closed to commercial shipping, straits.live, Day ~239 [continuity, single-sourced framing]
Transits	Still 4 vessels/day, Oct. 18 (IMF PortWatch) vs. 85/day baseline — now 8 days stale
Dark tankers	**not reported this cycle** — straits.live AIS feed quiet; Sat.'s 72.0%/180-of-250 reading has no follow-up
Crisis Pressure	88±10 Extreme, flat (band widened from ±8) — straits.live
Escalation Forecast	62±9 High, flat vs. 61±11 Sat. (within noise) — straits.live
War-risk premium	32.0x pre-crisis, still dated Oct. 7 — now 19 days stale, background only
Polymarket odds	**not confirmed as of press time** — no current Oct. reading found; dropped rather than carried stale

PortWatch (lagged AIS strait-transit count), straits.live's own AIS dark-tanker screen (sensitive to ambient dropout), UKMTO (advisories, none matching this period) and IRGC/state-media claims (no independent corroboration) measure different things over different windows — never averaged or differenced here. See Iran & Hormuz.

TRANSACTIONS

Yankees	Season over [continuity] — eliminated Oct. 7, swept 3-0 by Tampa Bay
Knicks	Lost 111-102 at home to Orlando, Sun. 10/25; now 0-3 [NEW]
Northwestern	Beat Rutgers 42-14, Sat. 10/24; now 6-1 (3-1 B1G), AP No. 20 [NEW]

LEAD

FOMC WATCH

Markets price a Wednesday hold, but the live question — and the one the Fed itself flagged in September — is a second rate hike in December

Correct the record from recent issues first: this brief has carried the Oct. 27-28 FOMC meeting as a live-but-thin cut debate, "~20%-24% odds, unchanged," as recently as Saturday. That framing was already stale. A cut has not been the real action this cycle. On Sept. 16, the Fed raised its target range a quarter point to 3.75%-4.00% — its first hike since July 2023 — citing a strong labor market, elevated inflation, and the energy shock from the Iran war, per TradingEconomics and RSM's reporting (sources disagree on the vote count: some report unanimous or 12-0, which sits oddly against a 9-3 hold-with-dissent the meeting before). [fact, correction]

That September meeting's projections matter more than this week's decision. Per RSM and TradingEconomics, 16 of 18 officials saw at least one more quarter-point hike as likely appropriate by year-end — a dot plot pointing straight at December. (Morningstar's own read of the same projections — that the median sees two hikes already done and no more — conflicts with that and is unreconciled here; treat as a single flagged discrepancy, not resolved.) [fact/flag]

Against that backdrop, Wednesday's decision is close to a formality: market-implied odds tracked across FXStreet, Invezz and CNBC's aggregation of CME FedWatch pricing (dated Oct. 22-24) put a hold at roughly 90%, a hike at 9-10%, and a cut effectively off the board. The December meeting is a different story — a hike there is priced at roughly 72%-80% depending on the tracker, up from about 70% shortly after Chair Warsh took the gavel in May. [fact, NEW/correction]

The mechanism worth watching: this is not demand overheating. The inflation the Fed is fighting is substantially cost-push — the same Iran-war oil shock that put Brent at a war-high $116.72 Friday before easing this morning — compounded by AI-capex demand and

resilient growth, not a classic wage-price spiral. [read] A December hike aimed at an energy-driven price problem risks slowing growth without doing much to its actual source, a tension Warsh hasn't been forced to resolve: he has said, as recently as Oct. 16, that he won't precommit to an outcome, a deliberate break from the Fed's standard practice of broadcasting its intentions well ahead of a meeting — odd, given how plainly September's own dot plot already did exactly that. [read]

The market's cross-asset reaction this morning is consistent with "hike risk deferred to December," not resolved: equity futures are modestly higher (S&P +0.30%, Nasdaq 100 futures +0.2%) on relief that Wednesday brings no surprise, even as oil and gold both ease rather than rally together, a tape that reads as repricing, not a clean risk-on or risk-off move. [fact/read] Watch Wednesday's statement and press conference for any language on December; watch Thursday's Q3 GDP and September PCE print, which lands as the next real data point in the hike-or-hold debate before the committee meets again.

ECONOMICS

Beyond the Fed path (Lead), Thursday's 8:30a ET release bundles the Q3 GDP advance estimate with September PCE and personal income — the last major data drop before December's meeting enters range. Unofficial consensus chatter circulating on finance calendars (not an official forecast, and not from BEA) puts GDP growth near +3.6% and core PCE near +3.1% y/y; treat both as pre-print chatter, not a number to repeat as fact. [flag]

OPEC+ meets Saturday, Nov. 1, with no agenda details verified this run — worth watching given Brent's pullback this morning from

Friday's war-high settle. Big Tech earnings dates (Microsoft, Alphabet, Amazon, Meta) and Coca-Cola/Boeing remain unverified against Nasdaq and CNBC's calendars for a second straight issue, despite the Thursday GDP/PCE print sitting in the same week [continuity, flag].

IRAN & HORMUZ

The most consequential item in the Hormuz file this morning is a denial, not a claim: CENTCOM said Sunday evening (Oct. 25, 18:04 ET per wire aggregation) that shipping routes remain clear of Iranian mines. No outlet has yet connected that statement by name to Saturday's IRGC claim that two supertankers were struck and disabled by naval mines — but the two sit in direct tension, and this is the first on-record US military comment bearing on that claim since it surfaced. [fact, NEW]

Fresh claims kept arriving regardless. Times of India reported Monday (02:40 ET) that Iran fired a cruise missile at vessels in the strait, and separately ran a headline (07:21 ET) asserting October is the highest-attack month on record — the latter a headline characterization, not a verified count, and both are single-sourced with no UKMTO or flag-state corroboration. [fact/flag, NEW] Gulf News reported Sunday afternoon that roughly 500 vessels are delayed amid a new tanker-attack claim; Al Jazeera reported an oil slick washing up on UAE beaches, prompting closures at Umm Al Quwain; separately, a video circulating as footage of an attack on an Emirati tanker was fact-checked Sunday as outdated, not current. [fact, NEW]

The quantitative counters this brief tracks went quiet rather than moving. PortWatch's transit count is unchanged at 4 vessels against the 85/day baseline, now 8 days stale — the longest unrevised stretch yet. straits.live's AIS dark-tanker screen, which jumped to 72.0% Saturday, has not updated; the feed itself is described as quiet, so Saturday's spike cannot be confirmed as holding or reverting. [fact/flag] Crisis Pressure (88±10, Extreme) and the Escalation

Forecast (62±9, High) are both flat against Saturday, though each index's own confidence band has widened — read as the tracker itself growing less certain, not as calm returning. [fact/read]

UKMTO has issued no advisory matching Oct. 24-26; its last confirmed advisory remains Oct. 20 (an interaction with military forces 121nm east of Duqm). Polymarket's odds on a return to normal transit, carried in every recent issue, could not be verified this run — third-party aggregators are stale or conflicting by months — so the figure is dropped rather than carried forward unflagged. [flag, continuity broken]

SPORTS

Yankees	Season over; eliminated Oct. 7, swept 3-0 by Tampa Bay in the ALDS.
Knicks	0-3; lost 111-102 at home to Orlando Sun. night — first defending champion to open 0-3 since the 2011-12 Mavericks.
Northwestern	6-1 (3-1 B1G), AP No. 20 (up from No. 24); beat Rutgers 42-14 Sat. at Ryan Field. Next: at Oregon, Sat. 10/31.
World Series	Brewers lead Rays 2-0 after a 5-4 Game 2 comeback win Sat. in Milwaukee; Game 3 tonight in Tampa Bay (FOX).

Continuity. Politics stays cut — no polling past the Oct. 20 Reuters/Ipsos 31%-approval reading already carried in issues No. 28-30; nothing moved. Business and Technology are cut — no verified M&A, corporate or tech news surfaced this run beyond the Fed story in the Lead. Geopolitics (Russia-Ukraine) stays cut — nothing dated past the single-sourced Oct. 11 item already dropped in prior issues. Rockets, frontier-AI releases and VC rounds: nothing verified this run.

Unverified figures are marked in red: today's UST yields, VIX, Asia/Europe closes, and Hormuz Polymarket odds (all not confirmed as of press time — stale sources were not carried forward); the Times of India mine/missile and record-month claims (single-sourced); unofficial GDP/PCE consensus chatter ahead of Thursday's print; the Morningstar vs. RSM/TradingEconomics discrepancy on how many 2026 hikes the Fed's own dot plot implies. Nothing was estimated or filled from memory.